service’. This diversity and balance within the nobility would remain the keystone of Mughal politics into the reigns of future emperors. It would result in the presence of courtiers who were very different from one another, men like Raja Todar Mal, Husain Khan ‘Tukriya’, Mirza Aziz Koka, Raja Bhagwant Das, Qulij Khan, and Faizi, with all their idiosyncrasies and clashing values who were nonetheless respected, loyal, and cherished members of the Mughal court.

This very personal moral code of conduct born of Akbar’s understanding of the many faiths and practices which he encountered, led to a loose collection of guidelines for those who might be keen to follow them, guidelines based on reason and rationality, and encouraging temperance and moderation in everyday life. ‘If people really wished it,’ Akbar offered, ‘they might adopt this faith, and his Majesty declared that this religion ought to be established by choice, and not by violence.’ Scholars M. Athar Ali and M. Akhtar Ali have shown that by using the terms of the Sufis, referring to his disciples as murids,* Akbar was aspiring to a position similar to that of a spiritual guide, but only for a very select band of men. ‘Whoever desires to be enrolled as a disciple,’ specified Abu’l Fazl, ‘finds great difficulty in his plea being accepted.’ Indeed, this was to be a close circle of aristocratic men willing to share the Padshah’s spiritual leadership, and in no way a popular mass movement. When German scholar Heinrich Blochmann was translating Abu’l Fazl’s works, he mistranslated the phrase Ain-i Iradat Gazinan (literally—regulations for those privileged to be His Majesty’s disciples) as ‘Ordinances of the Divine Faith’ and the idea of Din-i Ilahi and a new religion wrongly captured the popular imagination.

In reality, what took place in Akbar’s time was that a ceremony was organized in which the ‘disciple’, or murid, took an oath and was given a special seal that had the phrase ‘Allahu Akbar’ written on it. They were also given a small image of the Padshah, which they often wore pinned to their turban. Disciples were encouraged to greet each other with the phrase ‘Allahu Akbar’ to which the other would respond ‘Jalla Jallaluhu’. While these Arabic salutations were seemingly inoffensive, they also contained the emperor’s name within them (Jalal-ud-din Akbar). This audacious and even irreverent play on words would lead to considerable uneasiness and angst in those who accused Akbar of conflating his definition of kingship with that of divinity since the apparent meaning of the phrases ‘God is Great/May his Glory be ever Glorious’ could also be interpreted as ‘Akbar is God/May his